

Greed, Labour, Wages, and the Christian Moral Life

A Biblical and Theological Study of Wealth, Avarice, Human Dignity, and Fair Remuneration

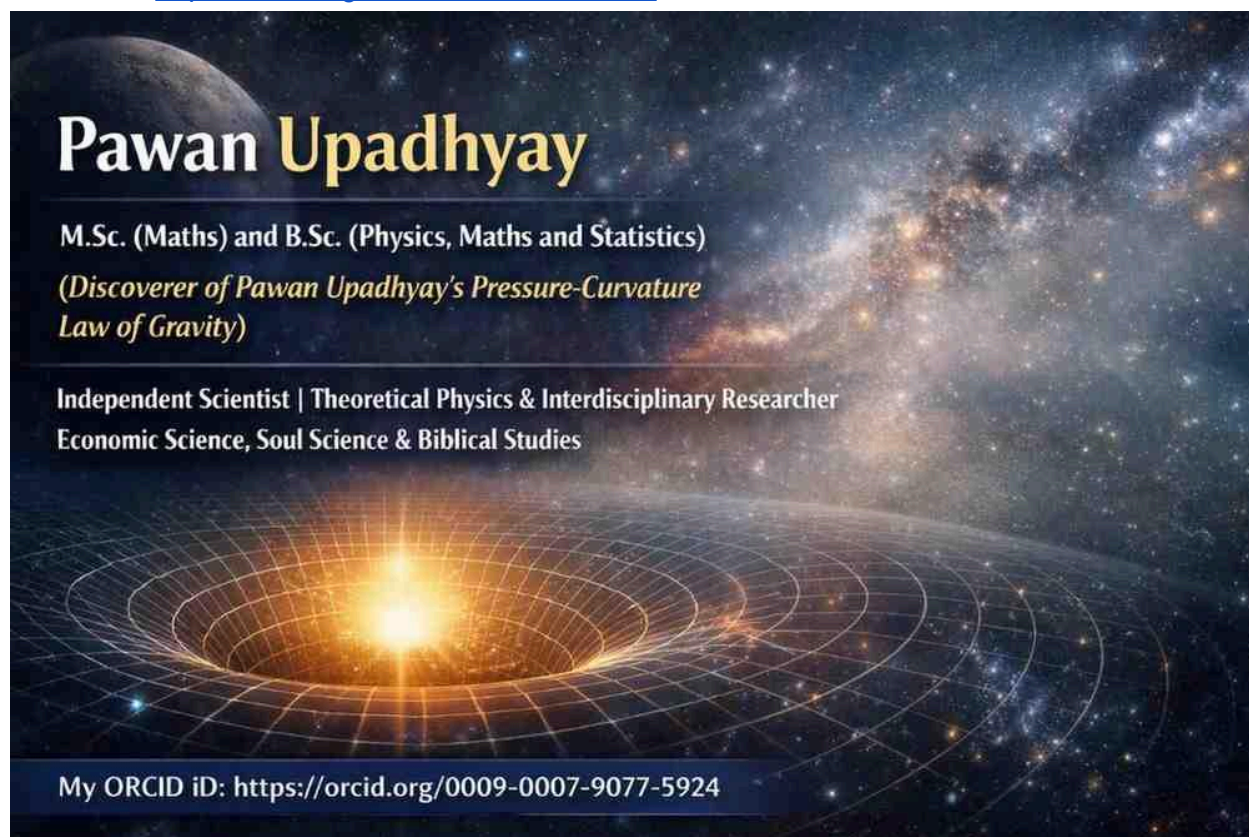
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Abstract

Greed has long been recognized within Christian moral theology as a serious disorder of human desire. It can transform wealth from a legitimate means of supporting human life into an ultimate object of devotion. The biblical tradition repeatedly warns against excessive attachment to material possessions, while simultaneously recognizing the legitimacy and dignity of work. This

apparent tension becomes particularly important when the teachings of Jesus Christ concerning wealth are considered alongside his statement that “the labourer is worthy of his wages” (Luke 10:7).

This research paper examines the relationship between greed, wealth, labour, wages, human dignity, and Christian ethics. It argues that Christianity does not condemn wealth, productive work, or legitimate remuneration in themselves. Rather, Christianity condemns the **enslavement of the human person to wealth** and the use of wealth in ways that violate justice and human dignity.

Jesus' warning, “You cannot serve God and Mammon” (Matthew 6:24), establishes an important spiritual principle: wealth must never become the master of human life. At the same time, his declaration that the labourer deserves wages establishes the legitimacy of receiving material compensation for labour. These two teachings are therefore not contradictory. Instead, they establish two complementary principles: **freedom from greed and justice toward workers**.

The study further examines biblical teaching concerning wealth and poverty, the Christian understanding of avarice, the dignity of labour, the just wage, and the relationship between capital and labour. It considers theological contributions from Augustine, John Chrysostom, Thomas Aquinas, and modern Christian social teaching. The Catholic *Compendium of the Social Doctrine of the Church*, for example, explicitly describes work as having dignity because the worker is a person and identifies the right to fair remuneration as a fundamental worker right.

The paper concludes that Christian economic ethics should neither glorify wealth nor despise honest prosperity. Instead, wealth should remain subordinate to God, work should respect human dignity, workers should receive just compensation, and economic power should be exercised for the common good.

Keywords: Greed, avarice, Mammon, wealth, labour, wages, just wage, human dignity, Christian ethics, Jesus Christ, economic justice, generosity, stewardship.

1. Introduction

Human beings require material resources to live. Food, clothing, shelter, education, healthcare, transportation, tools, and other necessities all require economic resources. Individuals therefore naturally seek employment, income, property, and financial security.

The Christian tradition does not deny these realities.

At the same time, Christianity has always warned that material possessions can become spiritually dangerous when human beings begin to place their ultimate trust in them. Wealth can move from being a **servant of human life** to becoming its **master**.

This distinction is essential.

There is a fundamental difference between a person who works honestly to earn a living and a person whose entire existence becomes dominated by the desire for wealth. There is a difference between financial responsibility and greed, between ambition and avarice, and between prosperity and the worship of possessions.

The central concern of this research is therefore not:

“Is wealth good or bad?”

The more important question is:

“What happens when wealth becomes the master of the human person?”

Jesus Christ addressed precisely this issue when He declared:

“You cannot serve God and Mammon.”
— Matthew 6:24

The statement presents wealth as something that can become a rival master.

Yet Jesus also said:

“The labourer is worthy of his wages.”
— Luke 10:7

This second teaching is equally important. It demonstrates that Christianity does not regard legitimate economic compensation as sinful. Jesus recognized that labour deserves remuneration.

The two teachings therefore create an important Christian ethical framework:

Do not worship wealth, but respect the dignity of labour.

Do not become greedy, but do not exploit workers.

Do not make Mammon your master, but allow honest labour to provide a dignified livelihood.

The *Compendium of the Social Doctrine of the Church* makes a similar connection, describing work as a fundamental human good and explicitly identifying the right to a just wage among the rights of workers.

2. Research Problem

The contemporary world frequently evaluates success in terms of income, property, consumption, business growth, investment returns, and accumulated wealth.

Economic development is obviously important. Poverty causes enormous human suffering, and economic security enables individuals and families to live with greater stability.

However, an excessive focus on wealth can produce serious moral problems.

When financial gain becomes the highest objective, other values may be sacrificed:

- honesty may be sacrificed for profit;
- workers may be treated merely as costs;
- consumers may be manipulated;
- corruption may be tolerated;
- environmental responsibilities may be ignored;
- family relationships may suffer;
- generosity may disappear;
- and human dignity may become secondary to economic efficiency.

The research problem can therefore be stated as follows:

How can Christian theology affirm honest labour, legitimate wages, and economic prosperity while simultaneously warning against greed, avarice, and the spiritual domination of wealth?

3. Research Questions

This paper addresses the following questions:

1. What does Christianity mean by greed and avarice?
2. Is wealth itself condemned in Christian Scripture?
3. Why did Jesus warn against serving Mammon?
4. What is the relationship between greed and sin?
5. What does Jesus mean by saying that the labourer is worthy of wages?
6. Does Christian teaching support the right of workers to fair remuneration?
7. How should employers understand their moral responsibilities?

8. How should workers understand their responsibilities?
 9. How have Christian theologians understood wealth and avarice?
 10. What principles can Christian ethics contribute to contemporary economic life?
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4. Research Thesis

This paper proposes the following thesis:

Christian teaching does not condemn wealth, honest labour, or legitimate remuneration; rather, it condemns the disordered love of wealth that turns possessions into a master and human beings into instruments of economic gain. Jesus Christ's teaching concerning Mammon and His affirmation that the labourer deserves wages together establish a Christian ethic in which wealth must remain subordinate to God, labour must be respected, and workers must receive just compensation.

This thesis has two dimensions.

The first is **spiritual**:

Human beings must not become slaves to wealth.

The second is **social**:

Human beings must not use wealth to exploit other human beings.

These two dimensions are inseparable.

5. Understanding Greed

Greed can be defined as an excessive or insatiable desire for wealth, possessions, money, power, or material advantage.

Importantly, greed should not be confused with simply possessing wealth.

A wealthy person is not necessarily greedy.

Similarly, a poor person can experience greed.

The moral issue is therefore not merely the quantity of possessions but the **relationship between the human person and possessions**.

A person may have considerable resources while remaining generous, responsible, humble, and concerned about others.

Another person may have relatively little while being completely dominated by envy and an obsessive desire for material possession.

Christian morality therefore examines the heart.

6. Greed and the Human Soul

The statement that “greed destroys the mind and soul” can be understood theologically as a statement about **disordered desire**.

Human beings naturally desire security.

They desire food, shelter, family stability, education, and a better future.

These desires are not inherently wrong.

The problem begins when legitimate desires become unlimited.

The person who constantly says:

“I need more.”

may eventually reach a point at which “more” has no natural limit.

This creates a dangerous psychological cycle:

desire → acquisition → temporary satisfaction → comparison → dissatisfaction → greater desire → further acquisition.

The cycle can continue regardless of how much wealth is accumulated.

Greed therefore has a paradoxical character.

It promises satisfaction while producing dissatisfaction.

It promises security while creating fear of loss.

It promises freedom while creating dependence.

It promises happiness while producing anxiety.

7. Greed and Moral Blindness

Greed can also affect moral judgment.

When money becomes the dominant objective, moral principles may begin to appear inconvenient.

An employer might think:

“If I pay workers less, my profits will increase.”

A dishonest businessperson might think:

“If I deceive the customer, I will make more money.”

A corrupt official might think:

“If I accept this payment, I will personally benefit.”

In each case, the economic calculation begins to replace the moral calculation.

The question changes from:

“Is this right?”

to:

“Will this make me money?”

This is one of the deepest dangers of greed.

It changes the question by which the person evaluates reality.

8. Greed and Sin

Christian theology does not claim that every sin is caused by greed.

Human wrongdoing has many causes.

However, greed can become a powerful motive for wrongdoing.

It can encourage:

- theft;
- fraud;
- corruption;
- bribery;
- exploitation;
- dishonest accounting;
- deception;
- manipulation;
- excessive consumption;
- abuse of power;
- and unjust treatment of workers.

The *Compendium of the Social Doctrine of the Church* similarly identifies the withholding of just wages, fraud, corruption, and other economic abuses as violations of justice.

Thus greed should be understood not simply as wanting money but as a moral disorder that can influence behaviour.

9. Jesus Christ and Mammon

One of the most important biblical passages for this subject is Matthew 6:24.

Jesus declares:

“You cannot serve both God and Mammon.”

The key word is **serve**.

Jesus does not simply say that money exists.

He says that Mammon can become something that a person **serves**.

This is a profound theological observation.

Money is supposed to be a means.

But when money becomes the ultimate objective, the relationship is reversed.

The human being begins to serve money.

The person wakes up thinking about money.

Works primarily for money.

Measures success by money.

Measures other people by money.

Measures personal worth by money.

And fears losing money above all else.

This is precisely what Jesus' warning about Mammon challenges.

10. Money as Servant Rather Than Master

Money itself can perform useful functions.

It can provide:

- food;
- shelter;
- education;
- healthcare;
- employment;
- investment;
- charitable assistance;
- technological development;
- and economic security.

Therefore, the Christian response cannot simply be:

“Money is evil.”

A more accurate Christian principle is:

Money is a useful servant but a dangerous master.

The problem is not the existence of wealth.

The problem is **the domination of the human heart by wealth.**

11. The Teaching: “The Labourer Is Worthy of His Wages”

Jesus' statement in Luke 10:7 provides the second major foundation of this research:

“The labourer is worthy of his wages.”

This teaching has enormous ethical significance.

It establishes the principle that labour deserves remuneration.

The worker is not merely providing an abstract economic input.

The worker is a human being who gives time, energy, knowledge, skill, creativity, and physical or intellectual effort.

The *Compendium* explicitly connects Jesus' statement with the Christian understanding of work and notes that “the labourer deserves his wages” applies to workers in the mission of the Gospel.

The broader Christian ethical principle is therefore clear:

Labour has value, and the labourer deserves appropriate compensation.

12. The Dignity of Labour

Christianity provides a deeper understanding of labour than merely viewing work as a way to make money.

Work can be understood as part of human participation in God's creation.

The worker creates, builds, cultivates, repairs, teaches, cares, organizes, serves, protects, researches, and produces.

The *Compendium* states that the dignity of work ultimately derives from the dignity of the person who performs it. It specifically warns against reducing work to a mere commodity or the worker to an instrument of production.

This principle is extremely important.

A worker is not merely:

“labour cost.”

A worker is a **person**.

13. The Just Wage

If the labourer deserves wages, the next question is:

What constitutes a just wage?

Christian social teaching answers that a wage should respect human dignity and should not be reduced to whatever amount can be extracted from a worker's vulnerability.

The *Compendium* explicitly states that the right to a just wage is a worker right and describes a just wage as the legitimate fruit of work. It also states that merely reaching an agreement between employer and employee does not automatically make the wage just.

This is significant.

A contract can be legally valid while still raising questions of justice.

For example, if a worker accepts extremely low wages because the worker has no realistic alternative, Christian ethics asks whether the economic relationship respects human dignity.

14. Employer Responsibility

Employers have legitimate interests.

Businesses must survive.

Investors expect returns.

Organizations need financial discipline.

Profit can be necessary for sustainability and employment.

Christian ethics does not require businesses to eliminate profit.

However, profit cannot become the **only moral standard**.

An employer has responsibilities toward workers.

These include:

- paying wages fairly;
- paying wages on time;
- maintaining safe working conditions;
- respecting workers' dignity;
- avoiding discrimination;
- respecting reasonable working hours;
- and avoiding exploitation.

The Christian principle can therefore be summarized:

Profit is legitimate; exploitation is not.

15. Worker Responsibility

Justice is not one-sided.

Workers also possess moral responsibilities.

A worker should:

- perform duties honestly;
- respect agreements;
- avoid theft;
- avoid deliberate negligence;
- use working time responsibly;
- respect colleagues;
- and contribute to the organization honestly.

The right to wages is therefore connected with the responsibility to work.

Christian ethics recognizes both **rights and duties**.

The employer must not exploit the worker.

The worker must not deliberately exploit the employer.

Justice requires reciprocity.

16. Wealth and Stewardship

The Christian understanding of wealth is closely related to **stewardship**.

Stewardship means recognizing that material resources carry responsibility.

The question becomes:

“How should I use what I have?”

rather than merely:

“How much can I acquire?”

A person may use wealth for:

- family;
- education;
- productive investment;
- employment;
- charity;
- community development;
- helping the poor;
- scientific and technological development;
- and other constructive purposes.

Wealth becomes morally meaningful through its use.

17. Augustine and Wealth

Augustine's theology emphasizes the importance of rightly ordered love.

The fundamental problem is not simply that human beings possess things.

The problem occurs when finite goods receive an ultimate love that belongs to God.

This is closely related to the concept of greed.

A person may love money so intensely that money becomes more important than truth, family, justice, compassion, or God.

Augustine's contribution therefore helps us understand greed as a problem of **love and orientation**.

18. John Chrysostom and Economic Responsibility

John Chrysostom frequently preached about wealth, poverty, generosity, and the responsibilities of wealthy Christians.

His preaching demonstrates that early Christianity did not treat economic questions as secondary.

The wealthy were expected to consider the needs of others.

Possession created responsibility.

This provides an important principle for modern society:

The possession of greater resources creates greater opportunities—and therefore greater responsibilities.

The prosperous person is not condemned merely because of prosperity.

But prosperity should produce responsibility rather than arrogance.

19. Thomas Aquinas and Avarice

Thomas Aquinas provides one of the most systematic Christian analyses of avarice.

Avarice is not simply the possession of property.

It is an excessive desire for material goods.

This distinction is crucial.

Aquinas' virtue ethics suggests that human desires should be ordered according to reason and moral purpose.

Possessions should serve human flourishing.

They should not control human beings.

The virtue of generosity helps establish this proper relationship.

The greedy person therefore suffers from an internal disorder.

The external possession is not necessarily the problem.

The problem is the **disordered desire**.

20. Labour and Modern Christian Social Teaching

Modern Christian social teaching developed these biblical principles in response to industrialization and modern economic systems.

The *Compendium of the Social Doctrine of the Church* explains that the Industrial Revolution produced both extraordinary economic development and serious exploitation of workers. It presents *Rerum Novarum* as an important Christian response to the worker question.

The *Compendium* emphasizes:

- dignity of work;
- worker rights;
- right to work;
- fair remuneration;
- rest;
- worker representation;
- social justice;
- and the relationship between labour and capital.

This demonstrates that Christian teaching about greed is not merely an individual spiritual teaching.

It has social consequences.

21. Labour and Capital

Modern economies require both labour and capital.

Capital provides:

- equipment;
- buildings;
- technology;
- financing;
- investment;
- and organizational capacity.

Labour provides:

- human effort;
- skill;
- knowledge;
- creativity;
- management;
- and service.

Neither should simply be understood as the enemy of the other.

The Christian goal is cooperation.

The problem occurs when one side treats the other as merely an instrument.

Capital should not treat labour merely as a cost.

Labour should not treat capital merely as something to seize.

Both should contribute to productive activity while respecting human dignity.

22. Greed and Exploitation

Greed becomes particularly dangerous when combined with economic power.

A person with little economic power may be greedy, but their ability to impose their greed on others may be limited.

A person with enormous economic power may be able to translate greed into institutional consequences.

For example, greed can influence decisions about:

- wages;
- working conditions;
- taxation;
- pricing;
- environmental responsibility;
- supply chains;
- corporate governance;
- and investment.

Therefore, Christian ethics must consider not only individual morality but also institutional morality.

23. Greed and Corruption

Corruption is one of the clearest examples of greed becoming a social problem.

Corruption occurs when public or professional responsibility is converted into private advantage.

The corrupt official says:

“What can I personally gain?”

instead of:

“What is my responsibility to society?”

This is a form of serving Mammon.

The public position becomes a tool for personal accumulation.

Corruption therefore damages more than money.

It destroys trust.

And trust is essential to society.

24. Greed and Crime

Greed may contribute to various forms of criminal behaviour.

These can include:

- fraud;
- embezzlement;
- bribery;
- theft;
- financial manipulation;
- exploitation;
- and corruption.

However, it would be academically incorrect to claim that greed causes all crime.

Crime has multiple causes.

The more defensible Christian claim is:

Greed can become a powerful motive for wrongdoing when the desire for material gain becomes stronger than moral responsibility.

This distinction makes the argument more academically credible.

25. Greed and Mental Peace

One of the deepest problems with greed is that it may destroy contentment.

The greedy person often lives according to comparison.

Someone else has a larger house.

Someone else has a more expensive vehicle.

Someone else has a larger business.

Someone else earns more.

Someone else possesses greater social status.

Thus, even significant wealth may fail to produce satisfaction.

The person remains psychologically poor despite being materially rich.

Christianity responds through **contentment and gratitude**.

Contentment does not mean refusing improvement.

It means refusing to make unlimited acquisition the condition for happiness.

26. Ambition Versus Greed

Ambition and greed should not be confused.

Ambition can be constructive.

A person may want:

- a better education;
- a successful business;
- a higher salary;
- a larger organization;
- professional recognition;
- or financial security.

These goals can be legitimate.

Greed begins when acquisition becomes detached from moral purpose.

Thus:

Ambition seeks achievement.

Greed seeks possession without sufficient moral limit.

Ambition can create.

Greed can consume.

Ambition can serve society.

Greed can exploit society.

27. Prosperity Without Greed

Christianity should not be interpreted as demanding universal poverty.

Economic prosperity can be beneficial.

A prosperous society can provide:

- better healthcare;
- education;
- scientific research;
- infrastructure;
- employment;
- technological innovation;
- and social security.

The Christian question is therefore not whether prosperity should exist.

The question is:

What kind of prosperity should society pursue?

The answer should be:

Prosperity with justice.

Profit with responsibility.

Growth with human dignity.

Wealth with generosity.

Enterprise without exploitation.

28. The Common Good

Economic life should ultimately contribute to the common good.

The *Compendium* places the human person at the centre of social and economic life and argues that economic systems must respect human dignity.

This means that economic success cannot be evaluated solely through total production or accumulated wealth.

We should also ask:

- Are workers treated fairly?
- Are families able to live with dignity?
- Are vulnerable people protected?
- Are opportunities available?
- Is corruption controlled?
- Is wealth used responsibly?
- Are human beings treated as persons?

Economic development without human development is incomplete.

29. The Sabbath and Limits on Work

The biblical concept of Sabbath provides another important principle.

Human beings are not machines.

Work is important, but work is not the ultimate meaning of life.

The *Compendium* notes that Sabbath rest provides a barrier against becoming slaves to work and against exploitation.

This principle is highly relevant to modern economic life.

A society can become obsessed with productivity.

People can become trapped in endless work.

The result may be:

- exhaustion;
- family breakdown;
- anxiety;
- loss of community;
- and spiritual emptiness.

Christianity therefore places a limit on economic activity.

Human beings work, but human beings are not created only to work.

30. Conclusion

Greed is more than an excessive desire for money.

It is a disorder in the relationship between the human person and material possessions.

When wealth becomes the ultimate objective, the human being risks becoming its servant.

This is the significance of Jesus Christ's warning:

“You cannot serve both God and Mammon.”

The warning is fundamentally spiritual.

Wealth must never occupy the place of God.

But Christian teaching does not end with a condemnation of greed.

Jesus also declared:

“The labourer is worthy of his wages.”

This establishes an equally important social principle.

The worker deserves recognition and remuneration.

Therefore, Christian economic ethics contains two inseparable commandments of moral responsibility:

First: Do not become a slave to wealth.

Second: Do not make another person a slave to your wealth.

The first protects the **soul of the wealthy person**.

The second protects the **dignity of the worker**.

Together they provide a powerful Christian framework for understanding economic life.

The Christian answer is not to condemn all wealth.

It is not to glorify all wealth either.

The Christian answer is to **order wealth correctly**.

Money should serve human beings.

Work should contribute to human flourishing.

Employers should respect workers.

Workers should perform their responsibilities honestly.

Wages should be fair.

Business should be productive but morally responsible.

Prosperity should create opportunities for generosity.

And no amount of wealth should become more important than God, truth, justice, compassion, and the human person.

The central lesson can therefore be stated simply:

Work honestly, earn legitimately, pay fairly, live generously, and never allow wealth to become the master of the human heart.

That is the balance between the two teachings of Christ: **freedom from Mammon and justice for the labourer.**

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[Expanded Research Paper]

Mammon in the Teachings of Jesus Christ

A Greek, Aramaic, Hebrew, and Theological Word Study

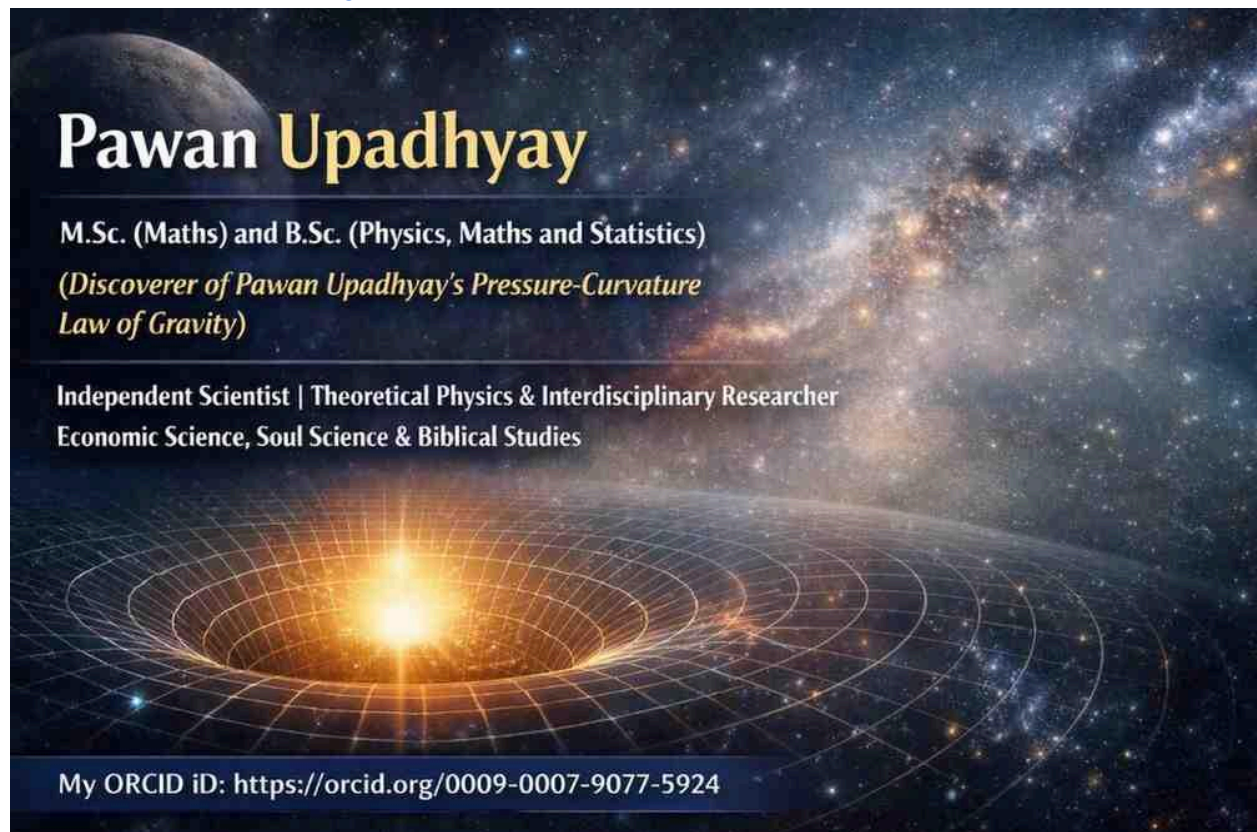
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Abstract

The word **Mammon** occupies a unique place in the teaching of Jesus Christ. In the New Testament it appears only four times: Matthew 6:24 and Luke 16:9, 11, 13. The Greek form is **μαμωνᾶς** (*mamōnas*), a transliteration of a Semitic term rather than an ordinary Greek word for money. The term is generally understood to derive from an Aramaic form **ܡܡܢܐ** (*māmōnā*), related to **ܡܡܢ** (*māmōn*), meaning wealth, property, money, or possessions. The

Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon records *mmwn* / *mmwnā* with meanings including money and wealth, while also attesting specialized meanings such as monetary indemnity and bribe.

This paper investigates the linguistic background of Mammon across Aramaic, Hebrew, Greek, and Syriac, and examines its theological significance in the teachings of Jesus. Particular attention is given to Matthew 6:24, where Jesus declares that a person cannot serve both God and Mammon, and Luke 16, where Mammon is described as “unrighteous.” The study argues that Mammon should not simply be equated with money itself. In Jesus' teaching, material wealth becomes **Mammon in the theological sense when wealth assumes the role of master, rival object of allegiance, or ultimate source of security.**

The paper further distinguishes Mammon from greed. Greed is the disordered desire for wealth; Mammon is wealth elevated into a controlling power. The study concludes that Jesus' teaching does not condemn honest work, legitimate property, or fair wages. Rather, it challenges the transformation of wealth from a servant of human life into a master of the human heart.

Keywords: Mammon, *mamōnas*, *māmōnā*, wealth, money, Aramaic, Hebrew, Greek, Jesus Christ, greed, avarice, Matthew 6:24, Luke 16, economic ethics.

1. Introduction

Few words in the teaching of Jesus have generated as much theological and cultural discussion as **Mammon**.

The word has entered many modern languages as a symbol of materialism, greed, excessive wealth, and the worship of money. In Christian literature, Mammon is sometimes portrayed almost as a supernatural being or demon of wealth. Historically, however, the linguistic evidence requires greater caution.

The basic Semitic meaning of the word is associated with **wealth, property, possessions, or money**. The word was used in Jewish and Aramaic contexts before and around the New Testament period. It was subsequently preserved in Greek as **μαμωνᾶς (*mamōnas*)**, rather than translated into an ordinary Greek term for money.

This preservation is theologically significant.

Matthew records Jesus saying:

“You cannot serve God and Mammon.”
— Matthew 6:24

Luke records essentially the same statement:

“You cannot serve God and Mammon.”
— Luke 16:13

The question is therefore not simply:

What does Mammon mean linguistically?

The deeper question is:

Why did Jesus place Mammon in direct opposition to God?

If Mammon simply means “money,” does Jesus mean that money itself is evil?

The answer appears to be no.

The linguistic and contextual evidence suggests something more profound. Wealth is morally dangerous when it becomes a **master**.

2. Research Problem

Modern societies depend heavily upon money and economic exchange.

People work for wages.

Businesses require capital.

Families require income.

Governments require taxation.

Education and healthcare require resources.

Savings provide security.

Investment can produce economic development.

Therefore, Christianity cannot simply teach that all money is inherently evil.

At the same time, excessive attachment to wealth can produce:

- greed;
- corruption;
- exploitation;
- dishonesty;

- inequality;
- anxiety;
- materialism;
- and spiritual emptiness.

Jesus' teaching concerning Mammon addresses precisely this tension.

The research problem of this paper is therefore:

How should the term Mammon be understood linguistically and theologically, and why does Jesus present Mammon as a rival to God?

3. Research Objectives

This paper has six principal objectives:

1. To identify the linguistic origin of the word Mammon.
 2. To examine its Aramaic and Hebrew background.
 3. To examine the Greek form *mamōnas* in the New Testament.
 4. To analyze Matthew 6:24 and Luke 16:9–13.
 5. To distinguish Mammon from money and greed.
 6. To develop a Christian theological understanding of wealth as servant rather than master.
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4. Methodology

This research uses a historical-linguistic and theological method.

It examines:

- Aramaic lexical evidence;
- Hebrew usage;
- Syriac evidence;
- Greek New Testament usage;
- biblical context;
- early Jewish literature;
- Christian theological interpretation;
- and Christian ethical implications.

The study deliberately distinguishes between **established lexical meanings** and **disputed etymologies**.

This distinction is particularly important because some traditional explanations connect *Mammon* with the idea of “that in which one trusts.” That connection is possible and has appeared in older lexicographical discussions, but the precise etymology remains uncertain. The safest lexical conclusion is that *Mammon* denotes wealth, property, money, or possessions.

5. The Aramaic Background

The strongest linguistic background for New Testament *Mammon* is Aramaic.

A reconstructed form is:

ܡܡܢܐ

māmōnā

The corresponding shorter form is:

ܡܡܢ

māmōn

The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon records **mmwn** / **mmwnā** as a noun meaning **money**, with meanings including **wealth** and **Mammon**.

This is significant because it demonstrates that the word did not originate as a uniquely Christian theological invention.

It belonged to an existing Semitic economic vocabulary.

The basic semantic field included:

- money;
- wealth;
- possessions;
- property;
- financial resources.

Consequently, when Jesus uses the word, His audience could understand its basic economic meaning.

6. The Emphatic Aramaic Form

Aramaic nouns can appear in an emphatic state.

The form:

ܡܡܠܢܐ — *māmōnā*

can therefore be understood as an emphatic form related to:

ܡܡܠܢ — *māmōn*.

This helps explain the Greek transliteration **μαμωνᾱς** (*mamōnas*).

The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon specifically lists:

mmwn, mmwnā — money; wealth, “Mammon.”

Therefore, the linguistic chain can reasonably be represented as:

Aramaic: ܡܡܠܢܐ — *māmōnā*

↓

Greek: μαμωνᾱς — *mamōnas*

↓

Latin: mammona

↓

English: Mammon

The English word therefore ultimately preserves a Semitic economic term through Greek and Latin transmission.

7. Hebrew: מַמּוֹן (*Māmôn*)

The Hebrew form is:

מַמּוֹן

māmôn

It is found prominently in later Jewish Hebrew rather than in the standard vocabulary of the Masoretic Old Testament.

The Hebrew word means:

- money;
- wealth;
- property;
- possessions;
- financial resources.

The Ben-Yehuda historical Hebrew dictionary records **מָמֶנֶה** with meanings including money, wealth, and property, and documents its usage in rabbinic literature.

This is important for our study.

It means that **Mammon was not originally a specifically Christian word.**

It belonged to the wider Jewish and Semitic linguistic world.

8. Mammon and the Old Testament

A significant observation is that **Mammon does not occur as a normal lexical item in the canonical Old Testament Hebrew text.**

This does not mean that the Old Testament has no concept of wealth.

Quite the opposite.

The Hebrew Bible has numerous words for:

- wealth;
- riches;
- silver;
- possessions;
- treasure;
- profit;
- property.

For example:

כֶּסֶף — *kesef*

Literally:

silver

and frequently used for:

money.

Another term is:

עֶשֶׂר — ‘ōsher

Meaning:

riches, wealth.

Another is:

הֶון — hōn

Meaning:

wealth, riches, substance, possessions.

Thus, the concept later expressed by *Mammon* is certainly present in Hebrew Scripture even though the particular word *māmôn* is not a regular Old Testament Hebrew term.

9. The Hebrew/Aramaic Relationship

The linguistic relationship between Hebrew and Aramaic is important because both languages belong to the Northwest Semitic linguistic family.

During the Second Temple and early rabbinic periods, Aramaic was widely used among Jewish communities.

Consequently, economic vocabulary could circulate across linguistic boundaries.

The evidence indicates that *māmôn* appears in later Jewish Hebrew, while related forms occur in Aramaic, Syriac, Targumic material, and other Jewish sources. One scholarly study notes that the word appears in Qumran material and later targumic and rabbinic traditions, while its New Testament occurrences are confined to Matthew 6:24 and Luke 16:9, 11, 13.

10. The Syriac Evidence

Syriac is a major dialect of Aramaic and became particularly important in early Christianity.

The Syriac form is represented as:

ܡܡܢܐ

mamōnā

This is significant because it preserves the same basic Semitic vocabulary.

Thus, the linguistic evidence does not require us to imagine Mammon originally as a pagan deity.

The lexical evidence points first toward:

wealth, money, possessions, property.

The theological personification develops from its use in particular biblical contexts.

11. Was Mammon a God?

This question deserves special attention.

In popular Christian culture, Mammon is sometimes described as:

“the demon of greed.”

But this interpretation must be distinguished from the biblical linguistic evidence.

The lexical sources do not establish that Jesus was naming an actual pagan deity called Mammon.

The *Encyclopedia of the Bible* explains that in Matthew 6:24 the term probably retains the ordinary meaning of material wealth rather than referring to an otherwise unknown god of wealth.

Likewise, older biblical scholarship observes that the idea of Mammon as a distinct deity or demon is not securely established from the New Testament itself.

Therefore, academically:

Mammon should primarily be understood as wealth personified as a rival master.

12. Greek: μαμωνᾶς (*Mamōnas*)

The Greek New Testament uses:

μαμωνᾶς

mamōnas

Strong's Greek lexical tradition identifies the term as **of Aramaic origin** and defines it as riches or wealth.

The important feature is that the Greek authors did not simply translate the word.

They **transliterated it**.

Instead of replacing *Mammon* with an ordinary Greek term for money, the Gospel preserves the Semitic word.

This gives the expression a distinctive rhetorical force.

13. Why Was the Word Transliterated?

The use of a transliterated word may preserve the cultural and rhetorical character of Jesus' saying.

Jesus could have been understood as saying:

“You cannot serve God and wealth.”

But the Gospel preserves:

“**You cannot serve God and Mammon.**”

The second expression is stronger.

It personifies wealth.

It gives wealth a name.

It makes wealth appear as a rival master.

The rhetorical effect is therefore:

God versus Mammon

rather than merely:

God versus money.

14. The Greek Verb δουλεύω (*Douleuō*)

Matthew 6:24 contains another extremely important word.

The verb is:

δουλεύειν

douleuein

from:

δουλεύω

douleuō

The semantic field includes:

- serving;
- being subject to;
- being a slave;
- serving as a subordinate.

Jesus therefore says:

οὐ δύνασθε θεῷ δουλεύειν καὶ μαμωνᾶ

Literally:

“You are not able to serve/be enslaved to God and Mammon.”

This changes the interpretation considerably.

Jesus is not merely discussing whether a person may **possess money**.

He is discussing **who or what possesses the person**.

15. Mammon as Master

The central theological idea is therefore:

Mammon is wealth when wealth assumes the position of master.

Money itself is an instrument.

But when the instrument becomes the master, the moral relationship is reversed.

The human being begins to live for money.

Money determines decisions.

Money determines relationships.

Money determines status.

Money determines identity.

Money determines moral choices.

This is what Jesus' warning exposes.

16. Matthew 6:19–24

Matthew's presentation is especially important because Matthew 6:24 occurs within a larger teaching about treasure.

Jesus first says:

“Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth...”

Then:

“For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.”

Then comes the statement:

“You cannot serve both God and Mammon.”

The progression is theologically meaningful.

Treasure → Heart → Master

What a person treasures affects the heart.

What controls the heart can become a master.

Therefore, Mammon is ultimately a question of **the heart's allegiance**.

17. Mammon and the Heart

The biblical concept of the heart is much broader than modern ideas of emotion.

The heart represents the centre of human thought, desire, intention, and decision.

Therefore:

“Where your treasure is, there your heart will be also”

means that economic choices reveal something about spiritual priorities.

This does not mean that every financial decision is a spiritual test.

It means that **persistent attachment to wealth can reveal the orientation of the heart**.

18. Mammon and Anxiety

Immediately after Matthew 6:24, Jesus teaches about anxiety concerning:

- food;
- drink;
- clothing;
- and tomorrow.

This connection is important.

Mammon promises security.

But excessive dependence upon wealth can create fear.

A person thinks:

“What if I lose everything?”

Then:

“I need more.”

Then:

“I need still more security.”

Thus wealth, which was supposed to reduce anxiety, can paradoxically become its source.

Jesus redirects the believer toward trust in God.

19. Luke 16 and the “Mammon of Unrighteousness”

Luke provides another important occurrence:

Luke 16:9

“Make friends for yourselves by means of the mammon of unrighteousness...”

Then verse 11 refers to:

“unrighteous mammon.”

And verse 13 repeats:

“You cannot serve God and Mammon.”

The phrase “**mammon of unrighteousness**” has generated considerable scholarly discussion.

It does not necessarily mean:

“money obtained illegally.”

Rather, it may refer more broadly to wealth belonging to the present fallen economic order and therefore capable of being used unjustly.

The lexical evidence confirms that *Mammon* itself means wealth or property; the moral qualification comes from the context.

20. Mammon Is Not Identical With Evil Money

This distinction is crucial.

If Mammon simply meant:

“money obtained through crime,”

then Jesus' statement:

“You cannot serve God and Mammon”

would be relatively narrow.

But Jesus' statement is much broader.

It concerns **wealth as a competing master**.

Thus, even legitimately acquired wealth can become Mammon if the person becomes enslaved to it.

21. Mammon and Greed

We can now distinguish two concepts.

Greed

Greed is:

the excessive or disordered desire for wealth.

Mammon

Mammon is:

wealth elevated into a controlling power or master.

They are closely related but not identical.

A useful formulation is:

Greed is the desire that seeks Mammon; Mammon is the wealth that becomes the object and master of that desire.

This distinction is valuable for Christian ethics.

22. Mammon and Avarice

The classical Christian tradition uses the word **avarice** for a disordered love of possessions.

Avarice is not simply wealth.

It is an excessive attachment to wealth.

Thomas Aquinas treats avarice as a vice opposed to liberality and examines the disorder involved in excessive desire for external goods.

Thus, the theological chain can be represented as:

wealth → attachment → avarice → domination by Mammon.

The possession itself is not necessarily sinful.

The disorder lies in the relationship to possession.

23. Mammon and Human Identity

One of the greatest dangers of Mammon is that it can redefine personal identity.

A person may begin to think:

“I am worth what I earn.”

Or:

“I am important because I own more.”

Or:

“People deserve my respect according to their economic status.”

This is fundamentally incompatible with Christian anthropology.

Christianity teaches that human dignity comes from the human person rather than from financial wealth.

A poor person does not possess less human dignity.

A wealthy person does not possess more human dignity.

24. Mammon and Social Class

When Mammon dominates society, economic value can become a measure of social value.

The wealthy may be admired simply because they are wealthy.

The poor may be treated as failures simply because they are poor.

This is a serious moral distortion.

Economic position can tell us something about resources.

It cannot tell us the value of a human soul.

25. Mammon and the Poor

Jesus' teachings about wealth cannot be separated from His concern for the poor.

The Christian tradition repeatedly emphasizes:

- generosity;
- compassion;
- justice;
- almsgiving;
- care for widows and orphans;
- and concern for vulnerable people.

If wealth becomes Mammon, the poor can become invisible.

The question changes from:

“How can my resources serve others?”

to:

“How can I protect and increase what belongs to me?”

This is precisely the moral danger Christianity seeks to overcome.

26. Mammon and Labour

The concept of Mammon also has implications for labour.

Jesus says:

“The labourer is worthy of his wages.”

— Luke 10:7

This statement provides an important balance.

Christianity does not teach:

“Money is evil, therefore workers should not receive wages.”

Instead:

The worker deserves just compensation, but wealth must never become an excuse for exploitation.

Thus, Mammon becomes especially dangerous when profit is prioritized above human dignity.

27. Mammon and Exploitation

Consider two economic approaches.

Approach A

“How can wealth serve people?”

Approach B

“How can people serve wealth?”

Jesus' teaching rejects the second.

When an employer sees workers merely as instruments for increasing profit, economic activity becomes spiritually distorted.

Workers become:

labour costs.

Customers become:

revenue sources.

Communities become:

markets.

Natural resources become:

commodities.

Human beings become instruments.

This is the social manifestation of Mammon.

28. Mammon and Just Wages

A Christian understanding of wages must therefore recognize both productivity and dignity.

A worker contributes:

- time;
- physical effort;
- intellectual effort;
- skill;
- experience;
- creativity;
- responsibility.

Compensation recognizes that contribution.

A just economic system cannot treat the worker as disposable.

The Christian principle is:

Profit may be legitimate, but exploitation is not.

29. Mammon and Business

Christianity does not require the abolition of business.

Businesses can:

- create employment;
- produce useful goods;
- provide services;
- innovate;
- generate tax revenue;
- support communities;
- and improve living standards.

The problem is not enterprise.

The problem is **enterprise without moral boundaries**.

A Christian business therefore needs to ask:

- Are workers treated fairly?
- Are wages paid properly?
- Are customers treated honestly?
- Is corruption rejected?
- Is profit pursued responsibly?
- Are vulnerable people exploited?
- Is wealth used for constructive purposes?

These questions move beyond legality into morality.

30. Mammon and Consumerism

Modern consumer culture presents another manifestation of Mammon.

Advertising frequently connects possessions with identity:

Buy this and become successful.

Own this and become attractive.

Purchase this and become respected.

The danger is that the consumer begins to believe that possessions can provide identity and happiness.

Christianity challenges this assumption.

A human being possesses value before purchasing anything.

31. Mammon and Technology

Technology has transformed economic life.

Money can now exist digitally.

Financial transactions can occur instantly.

Investment markets operate globally.

Algorithms influence consumer behaviour.

Digital platforms can generate enormous wealth.

These developments do not eliminate the teaching of Jesus.

They may make it more relevant.

Mammon does not require physical coins.

Mammon is ultimately about **the human relationship to wealth**.

Whether wealth exists as:

- coins;
- banknotes;
- property;
- shares;
- digital assets;
- or electronic balances,

the moral question remains:

Who is serving whom?

32. Mammon and Corruption

Corruption provides one of the clearest examples of Mammon's power.

A person entrusted with public responsibility may choose private financial gain over public service.

The person effectively says:

“My financial advantage is more important than my responsibility.”

This is the logic of Mammon.

Money has become the master.

33. Mammon and Crime

Mammon should not be blamed for every crime.

Nevertheless, excessive material desire can motivate:

- fraud;
- theft;
- bribery;

- embezzlement;
- corruption;
- financial deception;
- and exploitation.

Theologically, the problem is that wealth becomes more valuable than moral truth.

34. The Traditional Etymological Debate

One of the most interesting questions concerns the origin of the word itself.

Some older lexicographers connected *Mammon* with the Semitic root associated with **faithfulness or trust**, suggesting a meaning like:

“that in which one trusts.”

Thayer's lexicon records this traditional proposal, deriving the term apparently from the Semitic root **מנן** (*'mn*) and interpreting it as “what is trusted.”

Another proposal connects the word with a form related to **treasure** (*matmôn*).

The precise etymology, however, remains uncertain.

Modern lexical evidence establishes the meaning **money/wealth/property** much more securely than it establishes a particular derivation.

Therefore, an academically responsible paper should distinguish:

Established meaning

wealth, money, property, possessions

from:

Proposed etymology

that in which one trusts

The second may be theologically suggestive, but it should not be presented as certain.

35. “That in Which One Trusts”

Even if the etymological connection remains uncertain, the theological idea is remarkably compatible with Jesus' teaching.

Why?

Because Jesus' criticism of Mammon concerns **trust and allegiance**.

People can place their security in:

- God;
- wealth;
- political power;
- status;
- possessions;
- or human achievement.

Jesus challenges the idea that wealth can become the ultimate source of security.

Thus, although “that in which one trusts” should not be treated as a proven dictionary definition, it can function as a **theological interpretation of Jesus' usage**.

36. Mammon and Faith

Christian faith requires ultimate trust in God.

Mammon offers an alternative form of security:

“If I have enough wealth, I will be safe.”

But wealth cannot guarantee:

- health;
- life;
- love;
- peace;
- forgiveness;
- meaning;
- or salvation.

Therefore, Jesus directs the disciple away from absolute dependence upon possessions.

37. Mammon and the Kingdom of God

Jesus' teaching is ultimately eschatological.

The Christian is called to seek:

the Kingdom of God

rather than making earthly wealth the ultimate goal.

This does not mean refusing ordinary economic responsibilities.

It means placing economic life within a larger spiritual framework.

The order becomes:

God → Kingdom → neighbour → work → wealth

rather than:

wealth → power → status → self.

38. Mammon and Generosity

Generosity is one of the most effective Christian responses to Mammon.

Why?

Because generosity demonstrates that wealth does not own the person.

The person who gives freely says, in effect:

“My possessions are not my master.”

Generosity transforms wealth from an object of accumulation into an instrument of service.

39. Mammon and Contentment

The opposite of greed is not necessarily poverty.

One important alternative is **contentment**.

Contentment does not mean refusing to improve one's life.

It means refusing to believe that happiness depends upon unlimited acquisition.

The Christian can seek prosperity while remaining content.

The person can work hard without worshipping work.

The person can earn money without worshipping money.

The person can own property without allowing property to own the heart.

40. Theological Synthesis

The linguistic and theological evidence allows us to formulate the central argument of this research.

Linguistically:

Mammon means wealth, money, property, or possessions.

Contextually:

Jesus personifies wealth as a potential master.

Theologically:

Mammon represents wealth when it competes with God for human allegiance.

Ethically:

The problem is not possession but domination.

Spiritually:

The problem is not money itself but misplaced trust.

Socially:

The problem becomes exploitation when wealth takes priority over human dignity.

41. Mammon Is Not Money

This distinction deserves a clear statement:

Mammon is not synonymous with money in every context.

Money can be used:

- to feed a family;
- to pay wages;
- to support education;
- to fund charity;
- to build hospitals;
- to create employment.

Such uses do not automatically constitute serving Mammon.

Mammon appears when wealth becomes the **ultimate object of loyalty, security, identity, or desire**.

42. Mammon Is Not Wealth Alone

Similarly:

Being wealthy does not automatically mean serving Mammon.

A wealthy person may be:

- generous;
- humble;
- responsible;
- charitable;
- just;

- and concerned for society.

The Christian question is not simply:

“How much do you own?”

but:

“What owns you?”

This is perhaps the most concise theological interpretation of Jesus' teaching.

43. Mammon and the Human Heart

The deepest issue is therefore the heart.

Jesus does not simply attack economic institutions.

He addresses human desire.

A person can be surrounded by wealth without worshipping it.

Another can possess little while being consumed by the desire for wealth.

Thus, the battle against Mammon begins internally.

It involves:

- desire;
 - trust;
 - identity;
 - priorities;
 - gratitude;
 - generosity;
 - and moral responsibility.
-

44. Mammon and Christian Freedom

Christian freedom means freedom from slavery to false masters.

Mammon is one such master.

The person enslaved to wealth must continually acquire.

The person free from Mammon can say:

“I will use wealth, but I will not worship it.”

This is Christian economic freedom.

It is not freedom **from** economic responsibility.

It is freedom **from economic domination**.

45. Final Conclusion

The word **Mammon** has a rich linguistic and theological history.

Its immediate linguistic background is Semitic, especially Aramaic **ܡܡܢܐ** (*māmōnā*), related to **ܡܢܐ** (*māmōn*), meaning money, wealth, property, or possessions. The Greek New Testament preserves the term as **μαμωνᾶς** (*mamōnas*), rather than translating it into an ordinary Greek word for wealth. Lexical evidence confirms the basic meaning of money and wealth, while the exact etymology remains debated.

The significance of the word, however, goes beyond vocabulary.

Jesus takes an ordinary economic concept and places it into a dramatic theological contrast:

God versus Mammon.

The significance lies in the verb **δουλεύω** (*douleuō*)—to serve or be enslaved.

Jesus therefore presents the fundamental question not as:

“Do you possess money?”

but:

“Who is your master?”

Money can be a servant.

Wealth can support life.

Property can be used responsibly.

Business can create employment.

Workers deserve wages.

Prosperity can be beneficial.

But when wealth becomes the ultimate source of identity, security, power, and allegiance, it becomes Mammon in the theological sense.

Greed is therefore not simply the desire to have money.

It is the **disordered desire for wealth**.

Mammon is not simply money.

It is **wealth elevated into a rival master**.

And exploitation occurs when this mastership of wealth causes human beings to be treated as instruments of accumulation.

The Christian alternative is therefore not necessarily poverty, but **rightly ordered wealth**.

The correct order is:

God is the Master.

Human beings possess dignity.

Labour deserves justice.

Wealth is a servant.

Generosity defeats greed.

Jesus' teaching can consequently be summarized in one principle:

Do not allow what you possess to become what possesses you.

That is the deepest meaning of the warning against Mammon.

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Important scholarly conclusion

“The lexical evidence establishes Mammon primarily as a Semitic term for wealth, money, property, or possessions. Its precise etymology is uncertain. In the teaching of Jesus, however, the term is rhetorically personified and presented as a rival master to God. Thus, Mammon should not be identified simply with money itself, but with wealth when it assumes a position of mastery, ultimate trust, or allegiance in human life.”